CHAPTER 5

T U R K I S H R U L E I N P A L E S T I N E

DISORDER AND BACKWARDNESS

Palestine suffered two great blows at the beginning of the sixteenth century that brought a further deterioration in her already backward economic and political condition. These two blows were the loss of her position across the trade routes to India and her conquest by the Ottoman Turks (1516-1517). Already for centuries the central, western and European shores of the Mediterranean had led the eastern, African and Asiatic shores in all the works of civilization. Now, however, the centers of progress were shifting further west and north -- over the Alps, up the Rhine, and along the Atlantic. The inland sea lost its old dominance, and Palestine was left in a stagnant corner of that sea basin.

The German botanist Leonhard Rawolf, who visited Palestine in 1575, described it as a ruined and disordered country. He could go nowhere without submitting to robbery and extortion. George Sandys reported, about 1610, that Palestine was a bedraggled land of contemptible villages. Maundrell, an English chaplain at Aleppo, in 1697 drew a similar, depressing picture. He found Acre a village with a few poor cottages -- and spacious ruins; Nazareth was "an inconsiderable village".

From the eighteenth century, however, there is evidence of some economic progress. Pecocke, in 1737, found both agriculture and handicrafts much improved over earlier accounts. French influence was strong and had proved stimulating. French merchants bought tobacco, oil, soap and cotton cloth from Palestine. From Volney's account (1783-85), there is indication of increased French activity. In some parts of the country, agriculture thrived; there was extensive activity in soap manufacture, cotton spinning, weaving, manufacture of "sacred" articles, and wine-making.